



TP-LINK
TL-WR841N
Price: ₹2,000

Wireless Routers

Wireless routers are a very obscure category for most users. This is mainly because most users are unaware of the intricacies involved in correctly setting up and managing a router. Keeping that in mind, we would classify a good router as one that would be easy to setup and one that offers hassle-free performance. Judging by the numerous routers that have passed through our test centre so far, we would have to say that over the years, TP-LINK has impressed us with the performance of their devices. Relatively cheap, almost all their routers blow the socks off the competition. They are also extremely easy to setup and quick to respond, while giving plenty of customisation options to the power user.

There are a few things that you need to keep in mind before purchasing a router though. Dual-band routers are only important if you have devices that are capable of operating in that band, and your network is so congested that a single-band router is insufficient. This is not an issue in the average home environment so most of you will not require a dual-band router. NAS is another feature that is featured on routers nowadays and in our testing we found that accessing most NAS drives is a headache. Routers like the WD MyNet N900 Central which have an in-built HDD seem to have much faster access times and will be a better option if speed is a priority. Such devices do come at a premium though.



TP-LINK
TL-WR740N
Price: ₹1,100



ASUS RT-N66U
Price: ₹13,000



D-Link DIR
636L
Price: ₹5,000

USB 3.0 ports are mostly unnecessary, unless you intend to access your drive via LAN and not Wi-Fi, given the speed limitations. Gigabit Ethernet is an absolute must if transfer speeds are a priority, but for normal internet sharing and LAN gaming and such, a gigabit Ethernet port won't be required.

Zero1 Winner TP-LINK TL-WR841N

If it is performance you want, this is the router for you. The best performing router in our tests so far, this single-band router was almost twice as fast as most competing dual-band routers selling at more than three times the price. The signal strength was also excellent and while it lacks features such as USB, this much performance at such a low price (₹2,000), nets this router our Zero1 award.

Worthy Mentions TP-LINK TL-WR740N

At ₹1,100, this was the cheapest router in our tests and the performance at that price was astounding. The router performed much better than many of the more 'powerful' dual-band routers and though it is a very basic router, it does its job beautifully. For a basic home Wi-Fi setup, you really can't go wrong with this router.

ASUS RT-N66U

This was the best performing dual-band router in our tests. It is a bit expensive at ₹13,000, but it does include almost everything that you would need from any router, including DD-WRT support. While the router has USB ports (2.0) at the back, setting up an HDD can be a pain and while it isn't really recommended, the option is present if you really need it. Performance at 2.4 GHz is a bit lacking and it is only in the 5 GHz band that this router comes into its own. That said, the range at which this router can operate (at 2.4 GHz) is quite good, even if the speeds are comparatively lower than the TP-LINK TL-WR841N.

D-Link DIR 636L

This D-link router represents the best performance and value for money in the dual-band segment and even though it has a lower overall bandwidth (300N vs 900N) than monsters like the ASUS RT-N66U, the bandwidth should be sufficient for an average home user who wants/needs a dual-band capable router. The router itself has sufficient features for most usage scenarios and the USB port is just a bonus. Not a bad deal at ₹5,000.